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The Sangha in Theravada Buddhism

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Life is suffering. In Buddhism, it is believed that after death, people usually reincarnate and continue to experience this constant suffering. Buddhists understand this concept and shape their lives around it. In fact, “the distinctive feature of early Buddhism is that it made suffering and its elimination the core issue” (Smits, 10). People who successfully escape this reincarnation cycle of suffering achieve *nirvana* are known as *arhats*. However, performing this feat requires intense discipline and meditation. As a core stepping stone along the path of obtaining nirvana, followers of Theravada Buddhism gather in communities called *sangha* that provide environments to pursue discipline and *nirvana* (Smits, 15).

Like suffering, the *sangha* is a core component of Theravada Buddhism. In essence, the *sangha* is “the community of followers” who practice the Buddha’s teachings (Smits, 15). This community includes both male monks and female nuns. In order to demonstrate perseverance towards discipline and escaping suffering, these followers must adhere to a strict set of rules known as the *Vinaya*. The *Vinaya* outlines practices that should be avoided such as sex, consuming alcohol, stealing, or lying about your spiritual progress. However, it also details expectations that significantly affect daily life in the *sangha*. For example, it is stated in the *Vinaya* that monks must renounce almost all of their possessions and may only keep essential

things such as robes and begging bowls (*Excerpts from the Vinaya*). Moreover, it is forbidden for the *sangha* to obtain food themselves (Flynn). As a consequence of these strict rules detailed in the *Vinaya*, it is essential for the *sangha* to depend on laypeople.

The *Vinaya* essentially forces the members of the *sangha* to depend on laypeople for the essential things they need to survive. While the *sangha* discourages growing or creating your own source of food, it does allot time every day for monks to beg for food from the laypeople. While this may initially seem parasitical, the laypeople openly welcome this interaction with the *sangha*. Providing for monks benefits laypeople spiritually, and it gives them an opportunity to obtain spiritual guidance from the *sangha* (Flynn).

Living in this simplistic and bare manner allows Buddhist followers to devote more time towards another crucial aspect of becoming an arhat: meditation. Members of the *sangha* wake up early every day almost constantly practicing meditation (Flynn).

Works Cited

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